

Bible word study: Transgress* and how it relates to sin as defined by the Bible.

Word	Number of occurrences in the Bible
Transgress*	179 times in 172 verses
Transgress	14 times in 14 verses
Transgression	51 times in 50 verses
Transgressions	48 times in 47 verses
Transgressed	34 times in 34 verses
Transgressor	5 times in 5 verses
Transgressors	20 times in 19 verses
Transgresseth (third person singular)	4 times in 4 verses
Transgressest (second person singular)	1 time in 1 verse
Transgressing	2 times in 2 verses

(the asterisk “*” indicates the addition of any number of letters that when combined with the indicated prefix constitute a whole word)

The first occurrence of the word “transgress*” appears in [Exodus 23:21](#) (H6588, translated elsewhere as trespass, sin, and rebellion). The context is instructions given to Moses by God at Mount Sinai that Moses was to give to the children of Israel ([Exodus 20:22](#)).

Exodus 20:22

And the LORD said unto Moses, **Thus thou shalt say unto the children of Israel, Ye have seen that I have talked with you from heaven.**

Exodus 23:20-22

20 Behold, I send an Angel before thee, to keep thee in the way, and to bring thee into the place which I have prepared.

21 Beware of him, and obey his voice, provoke him not; for he will not pardon your transgressions: for my name is in him.

22 But if thou shalt indeed obey his voice, and do all that I speak; then I will be an enemy unto thine enemies, and an adversary unto thine adversaries.

Among other things, here we learn that a transgression is to disobey the voice of the Angel of whom the name of the LORD is in.

Take note that the word “Angel” (capitalized “a”) appears 4 times in 4 verses in the Bible ([Genesis 48:16](#), [Exodus 23:20](#), [Exodus 23:23](#), [Exodus 32:34](#)). While the Hebrew word for angel (מַלְאָךְ māl’āk, pronounced mal-awk’, H4397) is the same for both “Angel” and “angel”, the capital “A” clearly conveys a different meaning than the not-capitalized “angel”. The context of the first usage of “Angel” is when Israel was blessing Ephraim and Manasseh and it appears to refer to God ([Genesis 48:14-16](#)).

So, if disobeying the voice of God is called a transgression, then how does it relate to iniquity and specifically sin which are other words used in the Bible to describe disobedience to God?

In **Exodus 34:7**, **Joshua 24:19**, et. al. We learn that iniquity, transgression and sin are not exactly the same thing:

Exodus 34:7

Keeping mercy for thousands, forgiving **iniquity** and **transgression** and **sin**, and that will by no means clear *the guilty*; visiting the iniquity of the fathers upon the children, and upon the children's children, unto the third and to the fourth *generation*.

Joshua 24:19

And Joshua said unto the people, Ye cannot serve the LORD: for he *is* an holy God; he *is* a jealous God; he will not forgive your **transgressions** **nor** your **sins**.

Isaiah 44:22

I have blotted out, as a thick cloud, thy transgressions, and, as a cloud, thy sins: return unto me; for I have redeemed thee.

In **Leviticus 16:16**, **16:21** we learn that transgression and sin are very closely tied together (specifically, a transgression is a type of sin, and thus a transgression is always sin):

Leviticus 16:16

And he shall make an atonement for the holy *place*, because of the uncleanness of the children of Israel, and because of their transgressions **in all** their sins: and so shall he do for the tabernacle of the congregation, that remaineth among them in the midst of their uncleanness.

Leviticus 16:21

And Aaron shall lay both his hands upon the head of the live goat, and confess over him all the iniquities of the children of Israel, and all their transgressions **in all** their sins, putting them upon the head of the goat, and shall send *him* away by the hand of a fit man into the wilderness:

The first occurrence of the word sin is in **Genesis 4:7** where we learn that sin is the opposite of doing well (which is also acceptable to God). Therefore, sin can be roughly defined as “behavior that is not acceptable to God.”

Genesis 4:7

If thou doest well, shalt thou not be accepted? and if thou doest not well, sin lieth at the door. And unto thee *shall be* his desire, and thou shalt rule over him.

I **John 3:4** reveals more about the relationship between sin and transgression:

1 John 3:4

Whosoever committeth sin transgresseth also the law: for sin is the transgression of the law.

We need to dig a little deeper to better understand how transgression and sin are not exactly the same. To do so, lets do a case study from the Bible.

The context is Joshua, the children of Israel, and the events at Jericho and Ai.

1 Chronicles 2:7

And the sons of Carmi; Achar, **the troubler** of Israel, who **transgressed in the thing accursed**.

In Joshua chapter 7 we learn that Israel is defeated at Ai because:

Joshua 7:1

But the children of Israel **committed a trespass in the accursed thing**: for Achan, the son of Carmi, the son of Zabdi, the son of Zerah, of the tribe of Judah, **took of the accursed thing**: and the anger of the LORD was kindled against the children of Israel.

Joshua 7:11

Israel hath **sinned**, and they have **also transgressed my covenant** which I commanded them: **for they have even taken of the accursed thing, and have also stolen, and dissembled also, and they have put it even among their own stuff**.

The covenant is detailed in [Exodus 20:1-23:33](#).

Note: dissembled here does not mean to “take apart” or “break into constituent pieces” as we might expect (disassembled). It occurs 3 times in 3 verses ([Joshua 7:11](#), [Jeremiah 42:20](#), [Galatians 2:13](#)) and the biblical usage appears to agree with Noah Websters 1828 dictionary definition:

<https://webstersdictionary1828.com/Dictionary/dissembled>

DISSEMBLED, participle passive

Concealed under a false appearance; disguised.

In [Joshua 1:18](#) we learn that the officers of the people (v10,16) agreed that anyone that rebels against the commandment of Joshua shall be put to death:

Joshua 1:18

Whosoever *he be* that doth rebel against thy commandment, and will not hearken unto thy words in all that thou commandest him, he shall be put to death: only be strong and of a good courage.

Joshua's command regarding Jericho:

Joshua 6:17-19

17 And the city shall be **accursed**, even it, and **all that are therein**, to the LORD: only Rahab the harlot shall live, she and all that are with her in the house, because she hid the messengers that we sent.

18 And ye, in any wise **keep yourselves from the accursed thing**, lest ye make yourselves accursed, when ye take of the accursed thing, and make the camp of Israel a curse, and **trouble it**.

19 But all the silver, and gold, and vessels of brass and iron, are consecrated unto the LORD: they shall come into the treasury of the LORD.

1. The city and all that are therein are accursed to the LORD excepting Rahab and all in her house.
2. The silver, gold, and vessels of brass and iron are consecrated unto the LORD.

Achan's confession:

Joshua 7:19-22

19 And Joshua said unto Achan, My son, give, I pray thee, glory to the LORD God of Israel, and make confession unto him; and tell me now what thou hast done; hide it not from me.

20 And Achan answered Joshua, and said, Indeed I have sinned against the LORD God of Israel, and thus and thus have I done:

21 When I saw among the spoils a goodly Babylonish garment, and two hundred shekels of silver, and a wedge of gold of fifty shekels weight, then I coveted them, and took them; and, behold, they are hid in the earth in the midst of my tent, and the silver under it.

22 So Joshua sent messengers, and they ran unto the tent; and, behold, it was hid in his tent, and the silver under it.

- Achan disobeyed Joshua's command.
 - By taking of the accursed thing (the garment)
 - By stealing items consecrated to the LORD (silver and gold)
- Achan transgressed God's covenant.
 - By coveting (10th commandment, inordinate desire)
 - By stealing (8th commandment, taking what was not rightfully his)
 - Placing his opinion above God's (1st commandment, making himself god)
 - Placing his desire for material possessions above his desire for God (2nd commandment, idolatry).
- Achan sinned against God and thus "Israel hath sinned."
 - Behaving in a way that was unacceptable to God.

So, putting it all together we can conclude:

Sin is unacceptable behavior before God and to transgress describes the action of "crossing over" the boundaries set by God.

Extra

Let's take a moment and look at the word transgression itself and think about it's constituent parts and things that come to mind from each of them:

trans	gression
Moving across a border (transcontinental)	Aggression (the opposite of meekness)
Moving from one place to another (transport)	Digression (deviation, straying, deviation from a regular course)
Transfer from one place to another (transmit)	Regression (reversion, passing back or returning, turning your back to something and going the other way)

As a conceptual analogue, lets have a look at the formula for work and substitute (or, "Plug and chug" as a friend used to say):

$\text{work} = \text{distance} \times \text{force}$
$\text{transgression} = \text{trans} \times \text{gression}$
$\text{transgression} = (\text{moving past an acceptable point}) \times (\text{aggressively, forcefully})$

From the word itself, we can learn quite a bit as you can see. If we take what we learned earlier from the Bible we can see that transgression is "aggressively/forcefully crossing over an acceptable boundary set by God."

<https://webstersdictionary1828.com/Dictionary/transgress>

TRANSGRESS', verb transitive [Latin transgressus, transgredior; trans and gradior, to pass.]

1. To pass over or beyond any limit; to surpass.
2. In a moral sense, to overpass any rule prescribed as the limit of duty; to break or violate a law, civil or moral. To transgress a divine law, is sin.

TRANSGRESS', verb intransitive To offend by violating a law; to sin.

I Chron 2.

The first occurrence of transgress*, Strong's definition

Strong's: H6588 - pasha` - peh'-shah from 6586; a revolt (national, moral or religious):-- rebellion, sin, transgression, trespass. see HEBREW for 06586